

Episode 92: Once Upon a Time... (55) – *COO*What to Do About Shallow Waters? Flickering Light

The *Coo: Far From Home* memories I'm continuing to ramble about - actually, this work still hasn't been released on DVD. When it was originally released, Laserdisc (!) and VHS video were released during their heyday, but it still hasn't reached DVD release.

While writing these memories, sometimes I need to check the main episode screens. I have an old LD player at home, but checking the Laserdisc every time I need verification is troublesome. Moreover, I write manuscripts more often outside my home.

"Maybe I should burn this to DVD?"

I connected the LD player to an HD-DVD recorder and tried dubbing. Since it's such an old LD player, naturally it's analogue connection. I managed to dub it somehow, but ah, the noise... the colour... Apparently it's due to the old LD player. It's about 20 years old now...

I put that data on the laptop I carry daily, occasionally checking main episode screens while writing manuscripts. Then I end up getting absorbed watching and eventually watch the whole thing (laughs).

This movie is really good, well-made (laughs).

I wish it could somehow be re-released on DVD.

I wonder if I should petition somewhere? Hmm.

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home - watching test rushes of underwater footage, cuts of dolphins swimming in shallow waters, the director and animation director spoke up: "Something's missing."

What that was: "flickering light."

During daytime in oceans and rivers when water moves with waves and currents, the surface undulations create lens-like effects, casting net-like light patterns on the water bottom. While it doesn't reach deep areas, this "flickering light" should reflect on shallow sea floors and dolphins swimming in shallow waters.

"We definitely want this," said Director Imazawa.

So we decided to add this "flickering" to things swimming in relatively shallow underwater areas. We added "net pattern" animation for "flickering" to dolphins' upper body surfaces.

Now, what to do with this? The base animation was completed. But how to effectively show this on screen?

Several methods existed. First, during colouring, composite this animation and paint with "light-hitting" colours. Second, colour this "net pattern" as separate cel material in white, then photograph it with multiple exposure overexposure to create bright, blown-out colours (super). Third, create a transmitted light mask from this animation and apply transmitted light to literally add light, among others.

First, the colouring method was rejected because "it inevitably looks like 'net-patterned dolphins' swimming." The second photography super method also wasn't much different from colouring in the end, and we couldn't control brightness, darkness, and colour tone as desired, so it was rejected.

The third transmitted light method was the technique of applying "flickering light" directly, allowing various transmitted materials for the transmitted light applied, and from test results, it seemed quite promising.

However...

The ocean water itself, emphasising transparency, sought transparency that appeared completely absent (as if even seawater didn't exist), but for overhead shots looking down at the sea surface, we were adding transmitted light reflections to the sea surface so it was clearly recognisable as existing there. Without clear sea surface recognition, depending on cut continuity, it might look strange (like incorrect cuts).

This "sea surface reflection light" and "flickering light" conflicted. "Flickering light" should exist gently and faintly below that sea surface. But it subtly asserted itself, unfortunately creating busy, unclear screens.

"Well then, let's make it shadows instead."

Until now we'd been struggling to show "net patterns" brightly on screen as "flickering light," but we reversed the concept - use the "net patterns" themselves as shadows rather than light. So we coloured the "net pattern" black and used it with semi-exposure masking.

Test photography results: While honestly different from realistic appearance, it somehow conveyed the atmosphere and, more importantly, made underwater character performances stand out.

"Let's go with this," the director decided. Incidentally, seabed "net patterns" became "case-by-case," basically optional.

Today, various methods and techniques might express realistic shallow underwater scenes, and even then, pursuing it further might have achieved much more realistic shallow water depictions. But I think making it too realistic would somehow differ from what this work aimed for. The director and main staff all seemed to somehow share such feelings.

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